

4.2.Importance of Honesty Question and answer

Q1.Fatema is a senior engineer at a well-known construction firm. Her team is responsible for inspecting safety standards on a new residential high-rise project. During one of the inspections, she finds that certain safety protocols have not been followed. These include substandard quality materials and missing structural reinforcements in some sections.

When she informs her manager, he asks her to "**tweak the report**" to make the site pass the inspection, explaining that delays would cost the company a major client and financial loss. He assures her that "it's a minor thing" and that the building is "probably safe enough."

Fatema is torn between obeying her manager and staying true to her professional ethics.

(a) Why is **honesty important** in this professional context, and what should Fatema do?

(b) Based on the scenario what would be your recommendation?

Answer:

Importance of Honesty in Professional Ethics:

1. **Public Safety:**

In professions like engineering, healthcare, or finance, dishonesty can endanger lives. Falsifying safety reports can lead to accidents, injuries, or even deaths. In Fatema's case, dishonest reporting can result in a building collapse.

2. **Trust and Credibility:**

Professional honesty builds trust with clients, the public, and regulatory bodies. Once that trust is broken, the damage to reputation can be irreversible.

3. **Legal Consequences:**

Dishonest actions can lead to legal liabilities for both the employee and the company. If the building later fails or injures someone, Fatema could face criminal charges for falsifying safety documents.

4. **Professional Integrity:**

Honesty is a core value in most codes of ethics (e.g., the Engineering Code of Ethics, Medical Code of Conduct). Upholding honesty defines one's integrity and moral responsibility.

(b)Recommended Action:

Fatema should **refuse to falsify the report** and insist on accurately documenting the safety issues. She should escalate the matter to higher management or report to an external regulatory body if needed. While this may cause conflict or even risk her job, maintaining honesty protects lives and upholds ethical standards in the long run.

Q2. Rahman is a computer science student interning at a tech startup that develops a job recruitment platform. His team is responsible for maintaining the platform's AI-based candidate shortlisting algorithm.

While reviewing the code, Rahman discovers that the algorithm is **intentionally biased** — it lowers the ranking of applicants from certain universities and favors others. When he questions this, his team leader admits it's a “business decision” to impress high-paying clients who prefer candidates from specific schools. Rahman is asked to stay quiet and not document his findings.

Rahman knows that this practice is **unfair, discriminatory, and violates basic principles of transparency and ethical AI**.

(a) Why is **honesty important** in this professional computing context, and what should Rahman do?

(b) What will be your recommendation based on the context?

Answer :

Importance of Honesty in Computer Science Ethics:

1. Fairness and Non-Discrimination:

- Honesty ensures systems treat users fairly. Dishonest or biased algorithms can perpetuate injustice and social inequality, especially in high-impact areas like hiring, loans, and healthcare.

2. Trust in Technology:

- Users and clients must trust that the software they use is fair, secure, and ethical. If deception is discovered, it damages the credibility of the company and the entire profession.

3. Legal and Regulatory Compliance:

- Many countries have laws against algorithmic discrimination. Intentionally hiding or falsifying such issues can lead to serious legal consequences for both individuals and companies.

4. Professional Responsibility:

- According to professional codes of conduct (like ACM or IEEE), computer scientists must act with integrity, avoid harm, and be honest about system capabilities and limitations.

(b) Recommended Action:

Rahman should **document his findings** and raise the issue with a higher authority within the company or through an internal ethics board. If internal channels fail, he may need to report externally (e.g., to regulatory bodies). Even as a student, he has the responsibility to uphold ethical standards.

Silence would make him complicit in an unethical practice that could harm many job seekers and tarnish his future credibility as a professional.

Q3. Nusrat is a software developer working for a tech company that has recently launched a new mobile health-tracking app. The app collects users' health data including sleep patterns, heart rate, and location.

Nusrat notices that although the app claims in its **privacy policy** that data is used **only for improving user experience**, the company is **silently sharing anonymized data with third-party advertisers**.

When she brings this up, her manager says, “We’re not doing anything illegal. Everyone does it. It’s just anonymized data — no harm done.” She's also warned not to bring it up again or she might lose her job.

Nusrat knows that users trust the app with their personal health data and are unaware of the data sharing.

(a) Why is **transparency important** in computer science professional ethics, and what should Nusrat do?

(b) What is your recommendation based on the context?

Answer:

Importance of Transparency in Computer Science Ethics:

1. **Informed Consent:**
 - Users have the right to know how their data is being collected, stored, and shared. Without transparency, users cannot give informed consent.
2. **Building Trust:**
 - Transparent practices build user trust, which is essential for long-term success. Hidden practices can lead to public backlash and reputational damage.
3. **Accountability:**
 - Transparency holds companies and developers accountable for their actions. Without it, unethical practices can flourish unchecked.
4. **Ethical Data Use:**
 - Even anonymized data can sometimes be de-anonymized. Transparency ensures that ethical concerns are evaluated properly, not hidden under technical loopholes.
5. **Compliance with Laws:**
 - Global laws like the **GDPR** and **CCPA** require clear disclosure of data use. Lack of transparency can lead to legal action and heavy fines.

(b)Recommended Action:

Nusrat should first **document her concerns** and raise them through appropriate internal channels — such as the company’s legal or ethics department. If the company refuses to act, she may consider reporting to a regulatory authority or whistleblower channel, depending on the jurisdiction and legal protections.

Remaining silent would compromise her ethical responsibility to protect user privacy and uphold professional integrity.

Q4.Fahim is a final-year computer science student working on a capstone project in a team of four students. Each member is responsible for coding different modules, and they conduct peer reviews weekly to maintain code quality.

One of the team members, **Tuba**, is Fahim’s close friend. During a review session, Fahim discovers that Tuba’s code has serious logic flaws that could affect the project’s performance. However, since they are close friends and Tuba has been under stress due to personal reasons, Fahim is hesitant to criticize her work or suggest changes.

Instead of pointing out the issues in the group meeting, he gives her a “pass” and avoids detailed feedback.

Later, when the final project is submitted, the module Tuba worked on causes major bugs during the demo, affecting the entire team's grade.

(a) What conflict of interest did Fahim face, and what would have been the ethical way to handle the situation?

(b) What is your recommendation based on the context?

Answer:

Understanding the Conflict of Interest:

A **conflict of interest** occurs when a person’s personal relationships or interests compromise (or appear to compromise) their professional judgment or responsibilities.

In this case, Fahim’s **personal friendship with Tuba** interfered with his **professional duty** to provide honest, constructive feedback during a peer review — which is essential for team success.

Ethical Response and Handling:

1. Acknowledge the Conflict:

- Fahim should recognize that his friendship with Tuba could bias his evaluation, and therefore be extra cautious to act fairly and objectively.
- 2. **Prioritize Team Responsibility:**
 - His duty to the team and the project outcome must come before personal relationships. Ignoring bugs to protect a friend compromises the integrity of the entire project.
- 3. **Provide Constructive Feedback Respectfully:**
 - Fahim could have offered honest feedback during the review, and if needed, followed up with Tuba privately to offer help or support. Honesty doesn't have to be harsh.
- 4. **Seek a Neutral Reviewer (if needed):**
 - If Fahim felt strongly conflicted, he could have asked another teammate or the mentor to independently review Tuba's code.

(b) Recommendation:

This case illustrates that **handling conflicts of interest** is a crucial part of professional ethics in computer science. Personal relationships should not interfere with technical objectivity and team accountability. Failing to address such conflicts can lead to poor outcomes, damaged trust, and missed learning opportunities.